

MGTF418: Topics in Finance: Preparing for the CFA Exam

STUDENT CLASS (MQF)
FALL 2026

PROFESSOR Chris Girand, CFA

EMAIL chrisgirand@yahoo.com

OFFICE HOURS: Thursday from 10:30am-12:30pm, Bloomberg Lab (adjacent to IT)

DESCRIPTION

Up for a challenge? Only 39% of candidates attempting L1 exam passed the May 2026 exam. The Chartered Financial Analyst (CFA) designation is the industry-accepted gold standard for financial analysts. To earn the CFA charter you must pass three very challenging exams. Exam material draws from surveys of practicing analysts and covers 10 major topics. We will look at each of the 10 major topics areas (one per class) and explore the level of understanding that is required to pass the first level exam. We will do applied valuation work as tested on the actual CFA exams as well as highlight study habits of successful past candidates. We will pay special attention to sub-topics that aren't part of the core RADY MFIN program but that are covered on the CFA exams.

OBJECTIVES

At the close of this class you will be able to:

- Apply industry-standard investment valuation tools
- Prepare effectively for the 2026 and 2027 Level 1 CFA Exam,
- Get experience with Bloomberg Terminal

MATERIALS

Required

This class assumes you are a registered CFA level 1 candidate for the 2026 or 2027 exam, and as such will have access to the CFA-required readings. This material can be purchased separately if you are not registered. You will also need a CFA Institute-approved financial calculator (TI BAII or HP12c).

COURSE SCHEDULE

Students are expected to pre-read subjects being discussed in the class and to do practice questions on their own in between class. Grades are based on class participation and weekly, in-person, in-class quiz. No Zoom meetings unless mandated by the school. Class in-person participation is required as monitored by participation the valuation tournament (Jellybean contest).

Session	Date	Topic(s)	Reading(s)	Deliverable(s)*
1	9/24/26	Ethics	CFA Req'd Reading, "CFA Institute Code and Standard of Professional Conduct."	Instructor Slide Deck
2	10/1/26	Quantitative Methods	CFA Req'd Reading	Instructor Slide Deck
3	10/8/26	Financial Statement Analysis	CFA Req'd Reading	Instructor Slide Deck
4	10/15/26	Corporate Finance	CFA Req'd Reading	Instructor Slide Deck
5	10/22/26	Equity Investments	CFA Req'd Reading	Instructor Slide Deck
6	10/29/26	Fixed Income	CFA Req'd Reading	Instructor Slide Deck
7	11/5/26	Weapons of Mass Destruction (derivs)	CFA Req'd Reading	Instructor Slide Deck
8	11/12/26	Alternative Investments	CFA Req'd Reading	Instructor Slide Deck
9	11/19/26	Portfolio Management	CFA Req'd Reading	Instructor Slide Deck
10	12/3/26	Economics/Bloomberg Lab	CFA Req'd Reading	Instructor Slide Deck

ASSIGNMENTS & DELIVERABLES

[Explicitly designate whether specific assignments are individual or group, can or cannot involve consultation or collaboration. This will help foster academic integrity.

I – Independent, individual work only. No collaboration or consultation allowed.

C – Collaboration with classmates is allowed. However, each student must submit a deliverable.

G – Students may work together in groups and turn in one deliverable for the entire group.]

Reading Assignments - weekly reading assignments

Quizzes – weekly

Class Participation – required.

GRADING

Exams and Deliverables	Points [or percentage]
Class participation, canvas quizzes and in-class quizzes	100
Total	100

COURSE POLICIES

The over-riding goal for this class is for students to pass the CFA exams.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Integrity of scholarship is essential for an academic community. As members of the Rady School, we pledge ourselves to uphold the highest ethical standards. The University expects that both faculty and students will honor this principle and in so doing protect the validity of University intellectual work. For students, this means that all academic work will be done by the individual to whom it is assigned, without unauthorized aid of any kind.

The complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship can be viewed at:

<http://senate.ucsd.edu/manual/appendices/appendix2.pdf>

How the Honor Code applies to this course:

Honor code applies. In addition, all registered CFA Candidates are covered by the CFA Institute's Code & Standards

STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES

A student who has a disability or special need and requires an accommodation in order to have equal access to the classroom must register with the Office for Students with Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to the faculty member.

The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member in order to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. **No accommodations can be implemented retroactively.**

Please visit the [OSD website](#) for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities at (858) 534-4382 or fosorio@ucsd.edu.